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GEARS OF WAR

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The True Power Of Xbox 360**

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CLASSICGI

Where The Past Comes Alive



higher education
goes old school

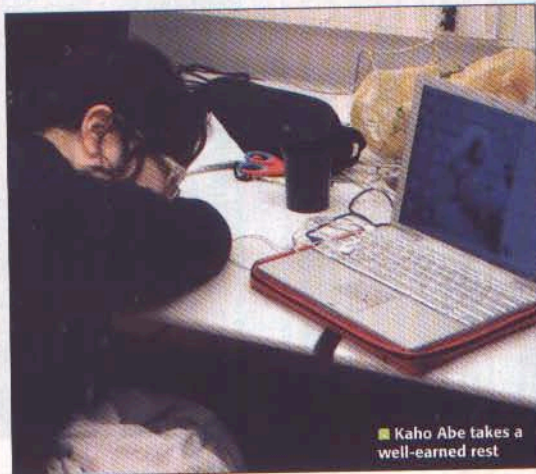
It's approaching 3:00 a.m. The familiar blips and bleeps of primordial video games are beginning to fill the a classroom where the students pound energy drinks and coffee to keep the midnight oil burning. The school members are playing *World of Warcraft* in the corner, and a 50-inch plasma television has been facilitating relieving rounds of *Katamari Damacy* for the past three hours. It may not sound like your typical college all but this isn't your typical university.



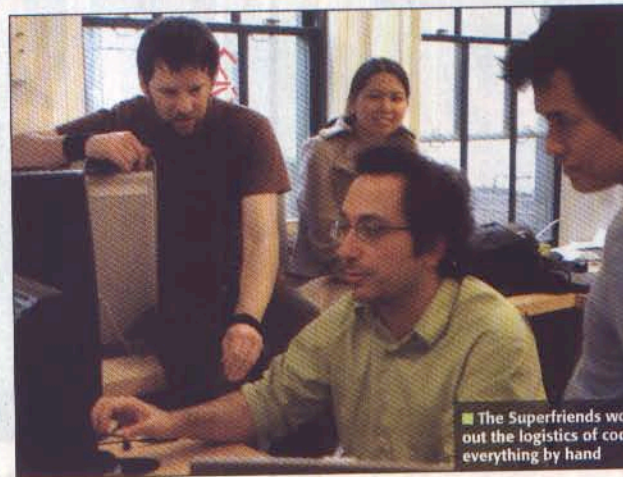
■ Program director Katie Salen helps Cynthia Arbore understand the Game Maker Software



■ G Bunch's Emily Gobeille works on elaborate background artwork



■ Kaho Abe takes a well-earned rest



■ The Superfriends work out the logistics of coding everything by hand



On April 2 and 3, the Design and Technology department of Parsons School of Design played host to a unique event: a 24-hour competition in which tomorrow's game developers test their skills against yesterday's technology. Dubbed "Retro Redux,"

the event challenges participants from five New York design schools to create a game to the specifications of the home console that defines old school: the Atari 2600. Every aspect of the title, from graphics to sound, must conform to the architecture of the venerable system that brought us classics like *Yar's Revenge* and *Adventure*. "By stripping away the focus on presentation, the students are free to focus on design," says Katie Salen, the event organizer and director of Parsons' design and technology program. Colleen Macklin, the department chair (who is wearing a hoodie emblazoned

with a skull and crossbones), elaborates: "Good design is good design, no matter what the constraints are."

Still, even the most dreadful of 2600 games required more than 24 hours to construct (*E.T.* took an entire month). As such, students are not expected to use the same development tools that helped shape the industry back in the early '80s. Instead, a program called Game Maker will be used because of its unfamiliarity to the participants and easy-to-learn interface. The team that uses this program to craft the most outstanding game not only gains a valuable learning experience, but also the distinct honor of having its title included on an upcoming iteration of Atari's nostalgic plug-and-play device, the Flashback.

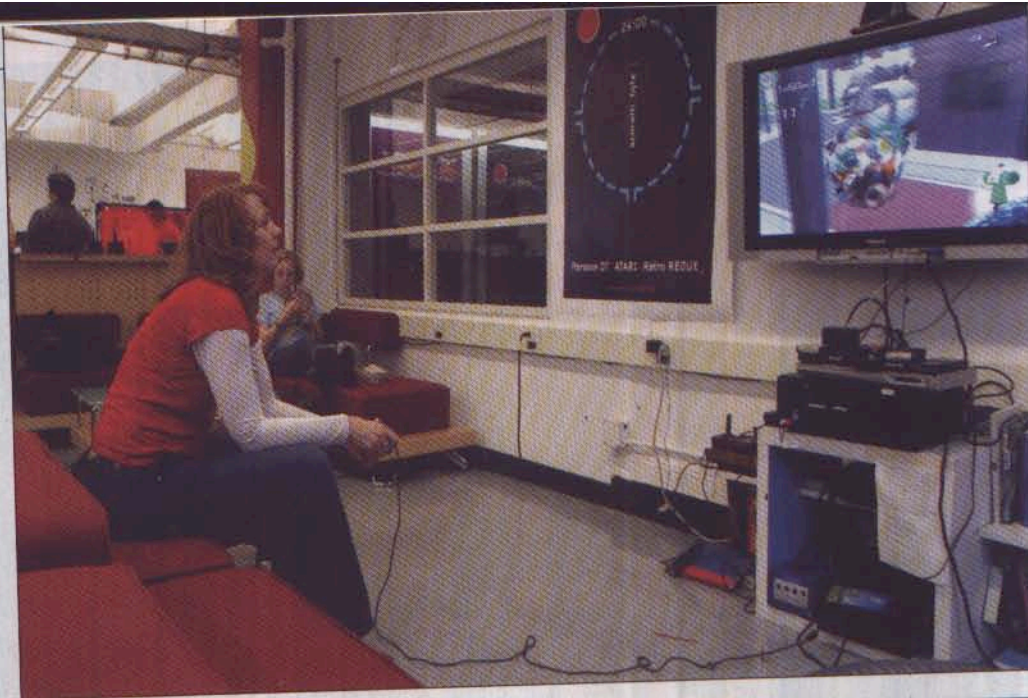
It may sound simple, but between 12:00 p.m. on Saturday and 12:00 p.m. on Sunday the groups will have to barrel through every aspect of making a game, from conception through execution. Add to that the inherent challenges of

learning new software, staying awake, and working in close quarters with conflicting personalities, and things are bound to get interesting.

As the teams begin to arrive and register, it is clear that each one will be contributing a unique personality and sense of style to the event. With names like *Gatorade Presents: The Thirst Quenching Fun Bunch From Rehydration Hill* (later shortened to "G Bunch"), *Superfriends*, and *Pixel Pirates*, the video game industry need not worry about a lack of creativity or humor from its future developers. Some teams even have a distinct fashion sense; the four members of G Bunch are each dressed as sports drink flavors like *Fierce Berry* and *Ice Orange*, wearing *Gatorade* labels as armbands. The modestly named *Club Awesome* is using this time to silk screen t-shirts with their pixelated team logo. The other teams, instead of worrying about their ensembles, simply collect themselves and enjoy the calm before the storm.



■ Priorities are important. Club Awesome attends to their t-shirt project before starting their game



“Good design is good design, no matter the graphical constraints.”



■ The trophies are actually fully functional Atari joysticks

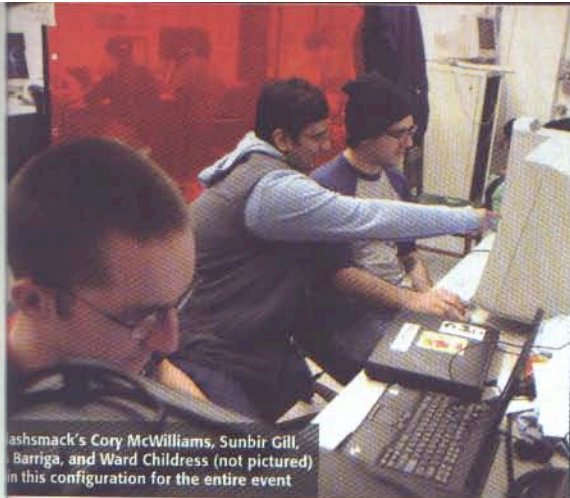


■ Matthia Romeo, Jason Corace, Victoria Fang, Austin Chang, and Aric Chestion gleefully watch digital piranha devour innocents

While they are here to make games for a historic system, these students have no plans to simply revisit concepts we've all seen before. In fact, three of the teams (G Bunch, QED, and Phatari) are composed of graduate students, each working on a thesis that explores and expands the boundaries of digital design. Brett Jackson is working on software for the Nintendo DS that would allow users to read comic books like e-books. Privthi Virasinghe is making a strategy game along the lines of Civilization that confronts the issue of globalization. Kaho Abe is working on new ways to integrate gaming and fashionable apparel. The days of games being simple lines of code are over, and with the next generation of consoles offering fewer restrictions than ever, the impact of artistic and creative design will only become more pronounced.

It is with this underlying emphasis on the purpose and potential of video games that all nine teams, when the clock strikes noon, energetically begin brainstorming and kicking off Retro Redux with a flurry of ideas that are so crazy they just might work. Among the most interesting is Club Awesome's desire to simulate online excitement along the lines of Splinter Cell; by using red and blue colored lenses to hide the corresponding colors onscreen, the team hopes to make a game about two ninjas in a field laying traps to eliminate each other. The Pixel Pirates are trying to invent gameplay around the concept of a character who mines Tetris blocks, while the teams from Mercy College (Show No Mercy and Bawls) push the boundaries of good taste by imagining a game that follows a baby's development from conception to delivery. As the outlandish and inventive ideas fly back and forth in the computer lab, each team does its best to craft a premise that will provide a unique experience while allowing them to showcase their creativity.

With preliminary work underway on most of the projects a crisis starts to take form. The contest rules are inconsistent on the subject of pixel resolution, and participants are unclear as to whether they should be using 14x7 (the Atari 2600 standard) or 4x2 (used for the Atari 7800) pixels. After some deliberation, Salen holds a meeting and all teams agree that using the 4x2 resolution would allow for more detailed graphics and, more importantly, expanded gameplay opportunities. Unfortunately, this also means that teams who have already begun working with the larger resolution will need to entirely rework their existing graphics. Team QED (a latin abbreviation for the phrase "which was to be demonstrated") from NYU is one of the teams hit hardest by the decision. They were working on an approximation of the Manhattan street grid for a car chase game, but now it is effectively useless. Incidentally, members of this team were also involved in an interesting real life/digital game hybrid project last year called "Pac



Flashsmack's Cory McWilliams, Sunbir Gill, and Barriga, and Ward Childress (not pictured) in this configuration for the entire event



Atari EVP Wim Stocks congratulates the participants for a job well done



Club Awesome clarifies their games' mechanics for Salen as she makes the rounds to check each team's progress



The two teams from Mercy College brainstorm as a single group before splitting off to work on their individual tasks

Top 5 Bizarre Quotes from Retro Redux

5 "Could you imagine if Papa Smurf was driving around Vice City and Smurfette was, well, you know..." Bryan Clarke, Show No Mercy

4 "There are more bananas on the ground, so the hand of God is moving faster." Matt Slaybaugh, QED

3 "Gatorade wouldn't sponsor a team called 'The New Facists.'" Brett Jackson, G Bunch

2 "Those stupid tourists all wear sombreros." Travis Griggs, Pixel Pirates

1 "New for the Atari 2600: matchless brutality." Aric Cheston, Superfriends

Ye Olde Gamesmith

The Game Maker software used by the students during the event is available for download free of charge at www.gamemaker.nl. Featuring action scripting and a drag-and-drop interface similar to Flash, it is a relatively painless way to break into homebrew gaming and start building up your own game design portfolio. Plus, it can handle games far more technically advanced than those it produced at Retro Redux.



hattan" that got a fair bit of attention on the Internet. Slightly upset about starting from scratch, QED decides to embrace the simplicity of the hardware and make an almost painfully basic game. "We're just going to make the simplest game we can think of," says Chris Hall. "A dot. And it needs to move across the screen. That's it." While they initially approach this new project with sardonic detachment, it seems to grow on them as they flesh out the finer details as the evening sets in.

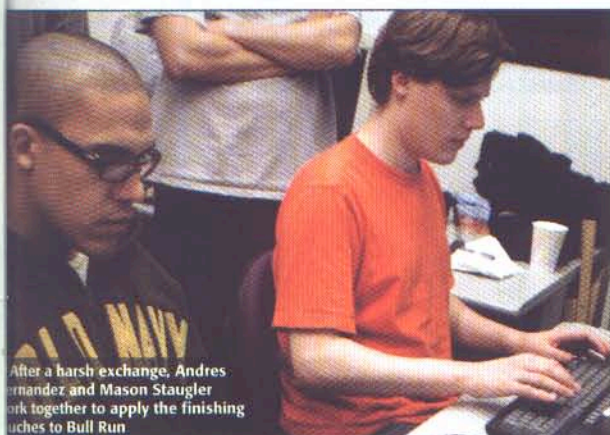
Other teams have been roaming around, holding animated discussions, and drawing level designs on whiteboards. Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute's Team Flashsmack have been stoically sitting in an orderly row, focused intently on their computers. What started as a game about a princess taking up the weapons of her father would-be savior has evolved into a genre-combining title that blends many mechanics from gaming's earlier eras. "The final boss fight will be really slick," explains

Ward Childress. "You'll stand on Breakout blocks, and you have to take out a giant Pong paddle." While they occasionally exchange jokes among themselves, Flashsmack generally has an unwavering focus on getting the job done which has left them further ahead of any other team in terms of having a playable, testable game.

Meanwhile, Club Awesome's multiplayer title hits a snag. While they have a lens that effectively cancels out the red ninja's actions, they are unable to locate a blue lens that will duplicate the effect. Team member Carol Chung sits with a phonebook open in her lap, searching for stores that might be able to accommodate them at this hour. Planning for the worst, they divide their efforts and begin work on another title. The rules state that a team is allowed to make multiple submissions, though the time constraints mean that it probably will lead to less time to playtest and refine any one concept.

The sky is brightening under the impending break of a

new day, and many of the teams are feeling the weight of an entire night spent staring at computer monitors. "I'm afraid that if I stop, I'm just going to die," quips Club Awesome's Theodore Watson as he replaces the placeholder graphics with fancy new sprites. The Superfriends are all sitting like statues in front of their computers, intently focused on fixing a problem in their game about a school of piranha. "It's a good action game," explains Aric Cheston. "It teaches you about real life, and what happens when you get eaten by vicious, ravenous fish." However, instead of using the Game Maker's graphic interface, the team chooses to do all of the coding by hand. While it does allow them to accomplish some effects not otherwise possible, it is very time consuming. When asked if he regretted the decision now, as others like Flashsmack are practically finished, Cheston simply responds, "Yep" with a resigned smile.



After a harsh exchange, Andres Hernandez and Mason Staugler work together to apply the finishing touches to Bull Run



Privthi Virasinghe, Donnie Budgen, and Jenks Whittenburg huddle over their noise-making squirrels to fly



Some teams have far more than technical difficulties on their hands. The School of Visual Arts' Pixel Pirates are exhausted not only from a hard night's work, but also from their personal interactions. They had settled on making a game about the famed running of the bulls, and while much

of the coding has been finished, team member Andres Hernandez is proving very difficult to work with. Though he is certainly pulling his weight, he refuses to relinquish any control over the scripting, and is harshly criticizing the contributions of his teammates. "That's done?" he snaps as he looks at a graphic made by Mason Staugler, "I'm not gonna say anything." "Then maybe you shouldn't," replies Staugler. "Well, I wasn't gonna say it," continues Hernandez, "but if that's finished, and it's an indicator of the quality of our game, then we're in some serious trouble." An uncomfortable silence follows as the team exchanges awkward glances. "This has been a persistent problem," Staugler later confides, "He's been like this every time I've worked with him." Despite all of the friction, however, the team continues to playtest and tweak the game for the remaining hours of the competition.

As the morning wears on, most teams are putting the

finishing touches on their games. The G Bunch has reassembled after a night apart (each team member worked on their assigned tasks at home), and they are now scrambling to bring all of the pieces together. In fact, by 11:30 a.m. all of the other teams have finished and have gone home for some well-earned rest, but the G Bunch stays until 1:00. Is that a violation of the rules? Not quite. From the beginning, this was to be a 24-hour competition. Oddly, no one seemed to realize that 2:00 a.m. on April 3 marked daylight savings time, making the night one hour shorter than usual. As a result, Macklin extends the event to accommodate the teams who feel they need the additional time, and this opportunity is all that allows the G Bunch to assemble their game (featuring a car that eats luggage) into a playable form.

With all of the entries turned in, the judges are left to play and evaluate. Four games will receive honors in the categories of best visuals, best audio, most innovative, and top overall game. Each winner will receive a trophy (mounted Atari joysticks), but only the top overall game will find a place on an upcoming Atari Flashback.

Fresh-faced and well-rested, the participants arrive at the awards ceremony on April 4 to learn how their games were received. Programming by hand paid off for the Superfriends as their title, Piranha, won for best audio

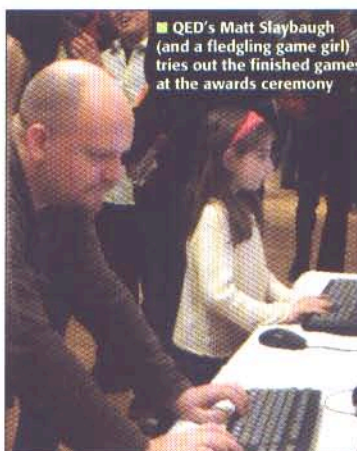
design, and despite some interpersonal problems, the Pixel Pirates' Bull Run was recognized for its superior visuals. The genre-defying Princess from Flashsmack won the team the trophy for most innovative, and even without colored lenses, Club Awesome's Ninja Garden snuck away with top honors.

"This is like the game geek equivalent of getting a book published," exclaims Evan Harper. "We spent so much time playing our own game, I thought we were just slacking. But it paid off." While the rewards are certainly exciting, most students agreed that the competition was never just about winning. It was about innovating with fresh design concepts while simultaneously paying respect to the technology that gave rise to the industry as we know it.

"We all grew up with these games. They're our history," articulates Carol Chung. Not only is it heartening to see our future designers so reverent of gaming's roots, but the submissions from all of the teams demonstrate a level of enthusiasm and ingenuity that promise to keep the industry alive and vibrant for years to come. If they produce these kinds of results with the architecture of an old Atari, the looming next generation of gaming could be even more promising than anyone had hoped. ■ ■ ■



Club Awesome's Raymond Zablocki, Evan Harper, Theodore Watson, Carol Chung, and Matt Brant showcase their game design skills and unique fashion sense



QED's Matt Slaybaugh (and a fledgling game girl) tries out the finished games at the awards ceremony



Gatorade-themed outfits was just one of many eccentric choices made by Retro Redux participants



game profiles:

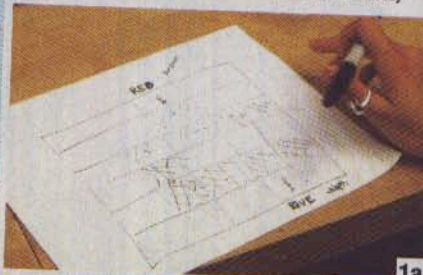


classic gi feat



1 Ninja Garden (Club Awesome)

Winner: Top Overall Game
Though the game underwent some necessary changes, the final product still closely resembles the original concept art (drawn on the back of the contest rules)



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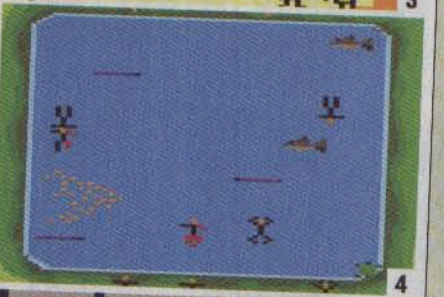
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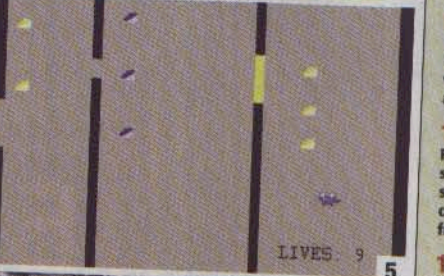
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2 Princess (Flashsmack)

Winner: Most Innovative Game
Honorable Mention: Top Overall Game
Breaking down and recombining gaming conventions, the highlight of this title is the final boss fight. It pits a socially conscious, self-rescuing princess against the First Father of Gaming (a Pong paddle) atop a stack of unstable Breakout blocks.

3 Bull Run (Pixel Pirates)

Winner: Best Visual Design
Set in the streets of Pamplona, Bull Run follows one bovine's gory exploits as he flees to France and freedom. The top-down scrolling city, detailed animations, and hilarious mutilations had this title trampling the competition in the graphics category.

4 Piranha (Superfriends)

Winner: Best Audio Design
As an ever-growing school of piranha, the player's job is to eat hapless swimmers while avoiding pond predators like turtles and sharks. The music is catchy, but what really distinguishes Piranha is the brilliant scream of terror made by swimmers as they are slowly (and bloodily) consumed.

5 Cats + Mice (Show No Mercy)

Honorable Mention: Most Innovative Game
The lesson to be learned here is that yellow cheese makes you big, and blue cheese makes you small. If you're a mouse, that is. This puzzler has you balancing your size as you negotiate maze-like levels filled with cats.

6 Cart Joust (QED)

Less like a game and more like David Lynch meets Supermarket Sweep, Cart Joust has you punching evil Mohawk babies and dodging floating heads, all from the comfort of a shopping cart. You'll never look at the Gerber baby the same way again.

7 Run Rabbit, Run (Club Awesome)

Club Awesome's ninja-free offering is cheerful jaunt through the woods as a fuzzy rabbit as he collects carrots and dodges wolves. It has a clever interactive title screen and some sweet pixelated trees, but the levels suffer a bit from a lack of variation.

8 Family Jewels (QED)

A familiar "cops 'n robbers" theme with a unique twist. Playing like a puzzle game, Family Jewels has you controlling three police officers simultaneously, coordinating movements to herd a bouncing thief into a jail cell.

9 Squirrel Jam (Phatari)

If you punch squirrels in the face, they make noise. In fact, according to Squirrel Jam, they make music. This unique sound-sequencing game has you hitting the flying rodents as they zoom by, attempting to line up the rhythms in a specified order.

10 Bawls (Bawls)

It isn't often that a game can cite both energy drinks and Breakout as inspiration. Bawls has players destroying various obstacles with a ricocheting ball as they travel down a 3D hallway.

11 Dot's Dash (QED)

Finding art in simplicity, Dot's Dash has you guiding a single pixel through a variety of mine fields. Featuring steadily increasing speeds, a manic soundtrack, and one random banana, it strikes a solid balance between frustration and fun.

12 Heart Castles (Show No Mercy)

As a heart exploring four areas littered with pixels, you try to amass as many points as possible within a set time limit. While not exactly filled with excitement, the concept of collecting random stuff is almost as old as the industry itself.

13 Lugzie Goes to Australia Heaven (G Bunch)

A story about a luggage-consuming car that goes through the layers of the earth to get to Australia Heaven. The gameplay is simplistic platforming, but the background visuals (especially the "Dentist at the Center of the Earth" level) are colorful and creative.